

Marxist training

The establishment of the world's first communist state in Russia split the international socialist movement. Left-wing activists everywhere faced a choice between social democracy and communism. In 1920, Ho made the fateful decision to opt for the latter. He wrote articles for the communist-backed anticolonial newspaper *Le Paria* and in 1923 traveled to the newly established Soviet Union, where he was taught to see the issue of Vietnamese independence in the wider perspective of the Marxist world revolution promoted by the Soviet-controlled Communist International (Comintern).

Ho's commitment to political struggle was absolute, with the only evidence for a personal life being his brief marriage to a Chinese woman in the mid-1920s. He was a faithful representative of Comintern, and it was in this role, in 1930, that he organized the various Vietnamese communist groups into a single Vietnamese Communist Party—which he renamed the Indochinese Communist Party after Comintern objected to the previous name's nationalist implications.

Leader reborn

After a period of obscurity, in 1940 he reemerged onto the stage of history as Ho Chi Minh—"bringer of light." This name represented a deliberate decision to present himself as a national leader in the Vietnamese Confucian tradition, embodying the virtues of age and wisdom. The move bore fruit after Ho's opportunistic declaration of Vietnamese independence in 1945.

The majority of the Vietnamese people readily accepted Ho as their legitimate leader, while the French were confused by his apparent moderation when he traveled to France for negotiations. In reality, Ho was moderate only out of political calculation. His alliances with noncommunist nationalists always ended in their exclusion from power and often their summary execution.